KCR'S RISE TO POWER



1974
Completes B.A. from Government Degree College, Siddipet, Andhra Pradesh

1980
Cuts his teeth in politics in the Indian Youth Congress's Hyderabad office, inspired by Sanjay Gandhi and the Emergency

1982
Elected chairman, Raghavapur Primary Agriculture Cooperative Society, Siddipet; appointed Youth Congress vice president of Medak district

1983
Joins the Telugu Desam Party (TDP); loses the first assembly poll from Siddipet to the Congress's A. Madan Mohan

1985
Wrests the Siddipet seat from the Congress

1987
Serves as the minister for drought relief in chief minister N.T. Rama Rao's cabinet until 1988

1989
Re-elected MLA from Siddipet; becomes district president of TDP till 1993



1993
Serves as chairman, Committee on Public Undertakings of the state legislature

1994
Elected MLA for a third time from Siddipet; becomes TDP state secretary

1996
Appointed transport minister in CM N. Chandrababu Naidu's cabinet

1999
Elected MLA and deputy speaker of the AP assembly



2001
Resigns from the post and TDP; floats the Telangana Rashtra Samithi (TRS) on April 27 at Karimnagar

2003
Serves as convenor, New States National Front

2004
TRS contests assembly and Lok Sabha (LS) polls in alliance with the Congress, wins 26 assembly and five LS seats. KCR elected MP

more than what KCR had guaranteed. The Congress has also very cleverly promised Rs 12,000 a year to farm labour, who find no place in KCR's schemes.

The Congress is also attacking KCR's chief claim of being the architect of Telangana. There would have been no Telangana if the Congress-led UPA government had not given it, they assert. The Grand Old Party, in fact, accuses KCR of betrayal, saying he had promised to merge his party if his demand was conceded, but then reneged. Ask KCR, and he claims that the betrayal was at the Congress end. What could prove to be the Congress's undoing is its failure to accommodate OBCs (Other Backward Classes) in larger numbers among the ticket-seekers. Analysts believe that unless there is a groundswell in the final fortnight of electioneering, the Congress could well lose the winning edge.

BJP'S PUZZLING DUALITY

While the Congress has strengthened its position as the main rival of the BRS, the BJP's fortunes have been fluctuating. The saffron party's graph seemed to have risen in the state in the past five years and it had won an impressive 48 out of the 150 seats in the Greater Hyderabad Municipal Council elections in December 2020. Significantly, it had also won two assembly byelections—in Dubbaka and Huzurabad—the latter by Etela Rajender, one of the founding leaders of the TRS and a prominent backward class face, who had defected to the BJP in June 2021. The BJP's campaign received a further boost when enforcement agencies named KCR's daughter, K. Kavitha, a former MP and now the Nizamabad MLC, in the alleged Delhi liquor scam that involved money-laundering. The BJP denied it, but the Enforcement Directorate case was largely seen as the party's attempt to get at KCR.

Then, just as suddenly and without any explanation, the BJP turned off the heat on KCR. In July 2023, four months before the polls, it replaced its state unit chief, Bandi Sanjay Kumar, a firebrand who had aggressively taken on KCR and his follies, using colourful vocabulary to irk him, with Union minister G. Kishan Reddy. However, since the latter has not relinquished his ministerial responsibilities, the appointment is being seen as a stopgap arrangement. Then, in September, the ED agreed not to summon Kavitha till the Supreme Court heard her plea on November 20. Both these developments conveyed the impression that the BJP had gone soft on KCR. Many thought it was because the saffron party would rather support the BRS than let the Congress win. Hence its attempt not to weaken KCR further.

However, in the past month and a half, the BJP has tried to correct the impression that it is secretly backing the BRS. In early October, at a public rally in Nizamabad, Prime Minister Narendra Modi 'revealed' that KCR had approached him to join the NDA after the BRS did badly in the GHMC polls in